Faith Tests Across the Covenants

In every era, God tests faith → and always on the far side of grace

"Remember… how he brought you these forty years through the desert so that he might, by humbling you, test you to see if you have it within you to keep his commandments."
(Deuteronomy 8:2)

Test, or Tempt?

Same event, two purposes → tell them apart

GOD TESTS

Hebrew: nasah (prove), bachan (assay/refine)
Greek: dokimazo (test to approve)

Purpose: to prove and refine → to bring genuine faith into the open and strengthen it. God tests toward LIFE.

SATAN TEMPTS

Greek: peirazo (in his hands: to entice to evil)

Purpose: to break and destroy → to make faith fail. The tempter aims at DEATH.

The same event can be both, from two sides: Job's loss, Peter's sifting (Luke 22:31–32 → Satan demanded to sift him; Jesus prayed his faith would not fail). One event; God's purpose to prove, Satan's to destroy.

God never tempts toward evil: ***"Let no one say when he is tempted, "I am tempted by God," for God cannot be tempted by evil, and he himself tempts no one."*** **(James 1:13)**

Key idea for the whole unit: a test is the scheduled occasion of sacrifice → the moment trust must cost something.

A Pattern in Every Covenant

God speaks → faith must become costly action

Era	Text	The test	What it asked
Eden	*Gen 2:16–17*	The one forbidden tree	Nearly costless to keep → a PURE test of trust in the word alone
Noah	*Heb 11:7*	Build an ark for "things not yet seen"	A lifetime's labor on a warning with no visible referent
Abraham	*Gen 22:1*	"God tested Abraham" → offer Isaac	Surrender the very promise → the first EXPLICIT test
Moses	*Ex 16:4; Deut 8:2*	Manna, Sabbath, the wilderness	Testing becomes covenant POLICY → "will they walk in my law or not?"
Kings	*2 Chr 32:31*	Hezekiah "left alone… to know his true motives"	The test moves inward → the heart when unsupervised

One shape, every era: God speaks → faith is asked to trust the word against sight, appetite, fear, or delay → obedience makes the invisible faith visible. The eras change; the shape does not.

Christ the Tested One

Forty days answering to forty years → and passing

"Then Jesus was led by the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. After he had fasted forty days and forty nights he was famished." **(Matthew 4:1–2)**

Israel: 40 years in the wilderness → tested, and failed. Jesus: 40 days in the wilderness → tested, and passed.
Every answer Jesus gives comes from Deuteronomy 6–8 → the very passages that interpret Israel's wilderness testing:
• *"Man does not live by bread alone"* (Deut 8:3) • *"Worship the Lord your God"* (Deut 6:13) • *"Do not put the Lord to the test"* (Deut 6:16)

He is deliberately retaking Israel's failed exam → as the true Israel, the true Son → **and He passes it clean (Heb 4:15: tempted in every way, yet without sin).**

And the passed test becomes the ground of our salvation:
"Although he was a son, he learned obedience through the things he suffered. And by being perfected in this way, he became the source of eternal salvation to all who obey him." **(Hebrews 5:8–9)**
The tested Son, having passed, becomes salvation's source → for "all who obey him."

Proving, Not Probation

The church's tests sit on the far side of a passed exam

Christ has already taken the decisive exam → Adam's, Israel's, ours → and passed. So, the believer's tests are no longer probation to earn a standing. They are the proving and refining of a faith that already rests on His finished work.

The exodus order settles it (again):
God redeemed Israel from Egypt by blood → ***and THEN*** tested them in the wilderness (Deut 8:2). The tests came **after** the rescue, to prove and shape a people already free. They never bought the freedom.

So, Scripture can call trials pure joy:
"The testing of your faith produces endurance… that the proven character of your faith → more valuable than gold → may bring praise and glory when Jesus Christ is revealed." **(James 1:3; 1 Pet 1:7)**

Grace saves. Testing proves. → Mercy first, altar second.

Discussion

Ten minutes → this is the week's practice

1. Why does God test people He already knows completely? If He knows the outcome, who is the test for?

2. Hezekiah was faithful for decades → what did being *"left alone"* reveal that forty good years had not? What might God's silence be testing in you?

Berean rule stands: *every claim goes back to the text → eager, and examining.*

Read Like a Berean

For next week → eager, and examining

For next week, read:

- **Acts 2:36–41** → the crowd is "cut to the heart" and asks *"what shall we do?"* What answer are they given → and how do they respond?
- **1 Corinthians 11:23–29** → what does Paul command a person to do before eating? Find the word "examine."

Next week: *The Church's Tests → obeying the gospel and the table. The covenant pattern, now applied to us.*

This week in one sentence:

Every covenant tests faith → and Christ passed the exam first. Grace saves; testing proves.

"by being perfected… he became the source of eternal salvation to all who obey him." (Hebrews 5:9)

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